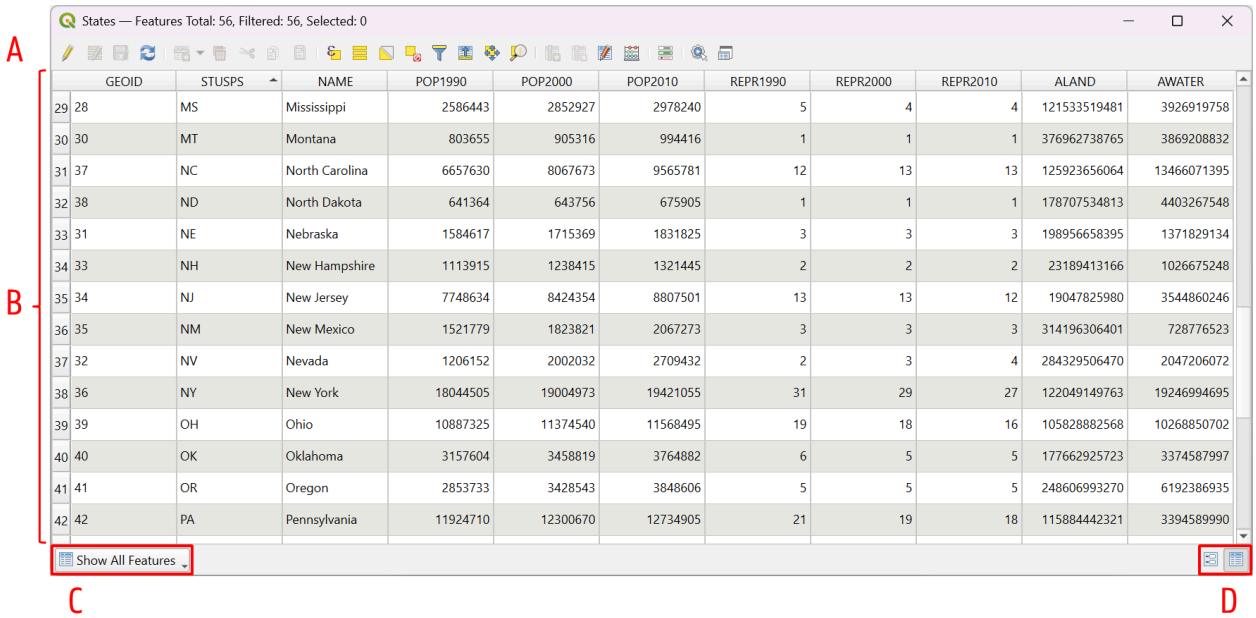
4.2.1 The attribute table

As you saw in The vector model, vector data combine two aspects: the geometry of each feature, which you see on the map, and the **attribute data**: the information linked to each feature, such as a name or a number of inhabitants. This page shows how to consult the attribute data in the attribute table, which brings together the attribute data of all features of a layer in one overview.

Opening the attribute table

You open the **attribute table** through the *Layers* panel: right-click the layer and choose *Open attribute table*. Alternatively, select the layer and press F6, or click the *Open Attribute Table* button on the *Attributes Toolbar*.



	GEOID	STUSPS	NAME	POP1990	POP2000	POP2010	REPR1990	REPR2000	REPR2010	ALAND	AWATER
29	28	MS	Mississippi	2586443	2852927	2978240	5	4	4	121533519481	3926919758
30	30	MT	Montana	803655	905316	994416	1	1	1	376962738765	3869208832
31	37	NC	North Carolina	6657630	8067673	9565781	12	13	13	125923656064	13466071395
32	38	ND	North Dakota	641364	643756	675905	1	1	1	178707534813	4403267548
33	31	NE	Nebraska	1584617	1715369	1831825	3	3	3	198956658395	1371829134
34	33	NH	New Hampshire	1113915	1238415	1321445	2	2	2	23189413166	1026675248
35	34	NJ	New Jersey	7748634	8424354	8807501	13	13	12	19047825980	3544860246
36	35	NM	New Mexico	1521779	1823821	2067273	3	3	3	314196306401	728776523
37	32	NV	Nevada	1206152	2002032	2709432	2	3	4	284329506470	2047206072
38	36	NY	New York	18044505	19004973	19421055	31	29	27	122049149763	19246994695
39	39	OH	Ohio	10887325	11374540	11568495	19	18	16	105828882568	10268850702
40	40	OK	Oklahoma	3157604	3458819	3764882	6	5	5	177662925723	3374587997
41	41	OR	Oregon	2853733	3428543	3848606	5	5	5	248606993270	6192386935
42	42	PA	Pennsylvania	11924710	12300670	12734905	21	19	18	115884442321	3394589990

The attribute table lists all features of the **vector layer** (B). Each row represents one feature, and each column one attribute field. You can easily sort the rows by any attribute field, numerically or alphabetically, by clicking a column heading.

Besides sorting, you can also select features in the table: click the number at the start of a row (hold down Ctrl or Shift to select several rows). A row in the attribute table and the corresponding geometry in the map canvas are linked in the background by a shared, unique **feature ID**. Because the geometric (spatial) and attribute (non-spatial) properties of a feature are inseparably linked, selecting a row in the attribute table also highlights the corresponding geometry in the map canvas, and vice versa.

Editing attribute data in the table is possible too, but not by default: first switch on editing mode with the *Toggle Editing* button (the pencil in toolbar A). We come back to this in Editing attribute data.

A vector dataset can contain many thousands of features, and so just as many rows in the attribute table. By default you see all of them, which can make the table hard to read. That is why the attribute table has a **filter function** (C), which offers several ways to reduce the number of visible features, for example to only the selected ones.

> **See also**
>
> The filter function is explained in detail on Filtering the attribute table.

By default, you consult the attributes in a table, as shown above. QGIS also offers a form view. To switch between the two, use the buttons at D.